

Q Will my baby with Down syndrome need to stay in the hospital longer?

Most likely, yes. Even if you were given a strong indication during pregnancy that your baby was likely to have the condition, Down syndrome won't be officially diagnosed until after the birth, when tests and checkups will be done in the hospital to confirm it. Firstly, a pediatrician will examine your baby to look for anatomical features that suggest Down syndrome is present. Then, he or she will do a blood test to see if your baby has an extra chromosome 21. Only once you have this chromosomal analysis—which may take up to 48 hours to come back, although timings vary from hospital to hospital—is the diagnosis given. Furthermore, babies with Down syndrome may have trouble feeding since a lack of muscle tone in the tongue can make sucking difficult. Like any mother of a newborn baby, you will be encouraged to stay in the hospital until you and your doctor are confident that your baby is feeding well.

Once you have the final diagnosis, your baby will need more tests to try to establish the degree to which she is affected by the condition. Effects can range from mild to severe—in the former case you may be allowed to go home soon after diagnosis, in the latter, your hospital stay may be longer.

Q What are the likely long-term challenges for babies with Down syndrome?

Although life expectancy for people with Down syndrome was once limited to middle age, men and women are now expected to live well into their 50s, and sometimes 60s. Increasingly, individuals with Down syndrome can live full lives, even leaving home as an adult to live independently. Nonetheless, the condition does pose certain challenges.

» **Weakened immunity:** your baby may be more susceptible to everyday infections, such as coughs, colds, and respiratory illnesses, although no one is really sure why this should be the case. Your baby is also more susceptible to serious conditions, such as leukemia.

» **Thyroid problems:** your baby is more likely than children without the condition to have to

take medication for hypothyroidism (an underactive thyroid). Even though this is relatively straightforward to control, this will be something that your baby will have to have monitored throughout her life.

» **Learning difficulties:** all babies with Down syndrome grow up to have some level of learning difficulties. Obviously, the more severe your baby's learning difficulties, the greater social and behavioral challenges she will then face. Problems such as impaired hearing and vision can exacerbate issues with cognitive function, since these can further delay several developmental stages, such as learning to talk, read, and write. Difficulty sleeping is

also a trait of the condition, and this too can further impede learning.

» **Dementia:** studies indicate that people with Down syndrome are more likely to suffer from dementia after the age of 40, which can lead to the need for long-term residential care.



Did you know...

Down syndrome is named after the 19th-century English doctor John Haydon Down, who first registered the condition in 1862.

Q What can I do to help my baby in the future?

Like any parent, your job is to help your baby reach her potential, not just in terms of learning, but also by helping her develop confidence in herself and to become as independent as possible.

Try to avoid comparisons with other babies without Down syndrome born at the same time, and instead celebrate your baby's successes as they happen. Tailor your parenting methods to her own unique learning styles—if she is creative, get creative with her; if she finds it hard to form words, teach her sign language; if she loves music, take her to music groups and as she gets older even learn to play an instrument together. Show her that she has unique talents, just like any other child, and in this way watch her grow in confidence and independence. Give her lots of opportunity to meet and play with other children, both with and without Down syndrome. Teach her social skills, such as manners and sharing, and offer her plenty of opportunities to socialize.

Finally, it's essential that throughout your parenting you work in partnership with the medical staff who are taking care of your baby—not just for her physical well-being, but also because this can help you to allay her fears or anxieties about any tests or procedures she may need to have.

Loving support With your constant support and love, your baby will grow in confidence and flourish, ready to take on challenges, knowing that you are there for her.

